

Boomtown

Campaign Vision & Yale Design Reference

A Cariboo Gold Rush (1858) town-builder / RTS-lite — design reference compiled from the Gold Rush Trail (2022) travel guide and design discussion between the project team.

Source caution: The Gold Rush Trail guide is a 2022 tourism publication. It is an excellent source for place names, photographs, geography, and broad historical framing — not a primary historical source. Treat it as a lead generator for further research, not a final authority on exact populations, dates, prices, legal rules, or cultural representation. Anything touching Indigenous history and culture specifically needs stronger primary sources and consultation before implementation.

Part 1 — Campaign Vision

The guide's biggest contribution isn't individual facts — it reveals the game's true structure. Boomtown is not only about finding gold. It is about how rivers, roads, freight, migration, Indigenous knowledge, government, and changing transport routes created — and destroyed — settlements.

1. Hope is the tutorial gateway

Hope sits at the Fraser–Coquihalla confluence and was already a long-established meeting point before the rush, later becoming the gateway to the Fraser and Cariboo goldfields. It should feel established, supplied, and relatively safe — the player learns claims, prospecting, trade, and employment here without founding a town from nothing.

2. Yale is the first dramatic expansion

Yale exploded during 1858, becoming a major river and wagon-road terminus squeezed between the river and steep mountains. Tight buildable land, a crowded riverfront, tent-city growth, sternwheelers and freight, high land value, dangerous canyon travel, rapid population pressure. Yale should feel far more intense and crowded than Hope.

3. The campaign follows a supply corridor

Settlements in the guide succeed because of their transport and supply role, not just nearby gold: New Westminster (provisions and tools), Yale (river/wagon-road terminus), Spences Bridge (ferry, then bridge), Ashcroft (freight transfer point), Quesnel (sternwheeler supply centre), roadhouses (food, lodging, provisions), and finally Barkerville as the destination and major urban boom.

*Core campaign loop: **Gold discovery creates traffic** → **traffic creates demand** → **infrastructure creates towns**. The player should profit from serving people moving through the region, not only from mining.*

4. Town decline matters as much as town growth

Quesnelle Forks prospered as a supply centre, then declined when the Cariboo Waggon Road bypassed it. No successful town should be permanently safe: roads change, new bridges bypass ferries, goldfields move, freight routes shift, populations relocate, property values collapse.

Implementation note: this is best treated as a campaign-map-level scripted/triggered event tied to road-tech unlocks, rather than a fully dynamic per-town economy simulation — keeps the payoff without a large, unproven systems investment before Yale's core loop is validated.

5. Transportation unlocks in historical stages

- Canoes and river travel
- Rope ferries
- Pack trails
- Wagon roads
- Stagecoaches

- Sternwheelers
- Bridges
- Later railway development

Each stage should change which settlements thrive — a more meaningful progression than generic road-tier upgrades, and potentially the mechanic that explains why new campaign maps open at all.

6. Roadhouses as a building category

Historic Hat Creek, Cottonwood House, 70 Mile House, 100 Mile House, and 108 Mile House show how important roadside accommodation was. A roadhouse could combine lodging, meals, stable service, general supplies, freight storage, mail, news/rumours, gambling or drinking, and a stagecoach stop into one multi-purpose frontier business.

Note: this is not really a Yale-era building — Yale's identity is river/wagon terminus and tent city, later a CPR camp. Roadhouses belong to the Lillooet-through-Cariboo-Road stretch of the campaign (70 Mile, 100 Mile, Cottonwood House). File away for whichever map follows Yale.

7. Indigenous communities are foundational, not decorative

The guide repeatedly explains that Indigenous peoples already had established settlements, trading routes, food systems, fishing grounds, cultural landscapes, and local knowledge before the rush. Newcomers relied on Indigenous guides, translators, food, canoes, trails, and trade to survive at all.

For Boomtown this means Indigenous characters should be part of navigation, trade, food supply, canoe transport, local geography, fishing, diplomacy, seasonal knowledge, and community relationships — not flavour NPCs. This area requires consultation and stronger primary sources before implementation.

8. Environmental progression should change radically northward

- Hope: wet, dense coastal forest
- Yale & Fraser Canyon: steep, constrained, rocky
- Lytton & Ashcroft: dry interior slopes
- Cariboo: forests, lakes, ranchland, colder seasons
- Barkerville region: remote mountain terrain, severe winters

Each map should feel environmentally distinct, not a reskin of one generic BC biome.

9. Wildlife and natural hazards support survival pressure

Bears, cougars, wolves, moose, elk, wolverines, wildfires, flooding, dangerous rapids, rock faces, and difficult routes can add pressure without turning Boomtown into a pure survival game.

10. Barkerville is the natural campaign climax

125 restored buildings and a full urban ecosystem — saloons, bakery, courthouse, Chinatown, theatre, stagecoaches, blacksmith, school, lodging, cemeteries, government. The point where the player is no longer building a rough camp, but managing a complex frontier city.

Suggested Campaign Structure

Stop	Role	Core Focus
Hope	Tutorial gateway	Prospecting, claims, trade, employment
Yale	Explosive boom port	River traffic, cramped terrain, tent settlement
Boston Bar / Hell's Gate	Dangerous transit	Ferries, canyon routes, isolated supply points
Lytton / Spences Bridge	River crossings	Agriculture, wagon-road infrastructure
Lillooet / Cariboo Road	Freight corridor	Roadhouses, stagecoaches, long supply chains
Quesnel / Quesnelle Forks	Logistics hub	Sternwheelers, route competition, bypass risk
Barkerville	Campaign climax	Large-scale mining economy, mature urban government

By the time the campaign reaches Barkerville, every town should have its own personality, economy, geography, and gameplay role instead of feeling like a reskinned map.

Part 2 — Yale Design Reference

A full pre-production design sheet for Yale, the first town built after Hope. The template below (historical timeline, gameplay identity, landmarks, terrain rules, economy, visual/sound targets, NPC population, expansion hooks) is intended to be reused for every future settlement.

1. Historical Timeline

Yale is built around its evolution, not a single snapshot. Boomtown focuses on the 1858 phase, but knowing what came later explains why certain buildings occupy the locations they do.

1858 — Tent City

- Tens of thousands of miners
- Canvas everywhere
- Temporary businesses
- Constant construction
- Mud
- River traffic

1860–1870 — Permanent Town

- Permanent wooden buildings
- Gold Commissioner's Office
- Hotels
- Churches
- General stores
- Government presence

CPR Era (later, reference only)

- Railway headquarters
- Construction camps
- Warehouses
- Freight yards

2. Gameplay Identity

Hope's identity: Learn to survive. Yale's identity: Handle chaos.

Everything should feel compressed: narrow streets, constant traffic, freight wagons, horses, miners everywhere, steam whistles, sternwheelers, gambling, competing businesses. Hope is calm. Yale is loud.

3. Landmark List

Landmark	Gameplay Role
Tent City	Cheap lodging, labor hiring

Creighton House	Wealthier merchant district
St. John the Divine	Community events, morale
Ward Tea House	Information gathering
Pioneer Cemetery	Historical storytelling
Spirit Caves	Exploration
River Landing	Cargo, ferries, sternwheelers

Reference: the 1868 photograph of Yale (Gold Rush Trail guide, p.11) shows buildings forming a narrow strip along the bank beneath a steep mountain wall — use directly as terrain-blocking reference, the same way Hope_1858_RiverData drove the riverbank correction work on Hope.

4. Terrain Rules

The terrain should dictate the town — not the other way around.

- Fraser River dominates one side
- Mountains dominate the other
- Limited expansion space
- Buildings forced into long ribbons
- Steep side streets
- Constant elevation change

5. Economy

Separate income streams, not just mining:

- Prospecting
- Claim registration
- General stores
- Freight
- Hotels
- Saloons
- Blacksmiths
- Stables
- River transport

The player should realize they don't have to mine forever — many of the richest people historically supplied miners rather than swinging picks themselves.

6. Visual Targets

Extract from period photographs for the Blender reference pack:

- Roof pitch
- Boardwalk width
- Fence construction
- Barrel placement
- Mud depth
- Building spacing
- Window styles
- Chimneys
- Street clutter

7. Soundscape

- Steam whistles
- Horses
- Hammering
- Sawing
- River current
- Chinese conversations
- Church bell
- Gambling halls
- Blacksmith anvils
- Dogs
- Freight wagons

A believable soundscape will make Yale feel alive.

8. NPC Population

Not just “citizens” — distinct groups, each with their own schedules and economic roles:

- Prospectors
- Merchants
- Blacksmiths
- Teamsters
- Boat crews
- Ferry operators
- Surveyors
- Police
- Gold Commissioners
- Carpenters
- Hotel owners

- Cooks
- Indigenous traders and guides
- Chinese merchants and workers
- Travelers heading north

9. Future Expansion Hooks

- Stagecoaches
- Sternwheelers
- Freight contracts
- Supply shortages
- Newspaper events
- Fire disasters
- Floods
- Claim rushes
- New discoveries upstream

Part 3 — Settlement Design Sheets

One design sheet (matching Part 2's template) should exist for every major settlement before it is built in Unity. This is preparation that pays off during development: rather than asking “what should this town have?” after opening the editor, its identity, landmarks, terrain constraints, economy, and atmosphere are already known before the first building is placed.

Settlement	Role	Status
Hope	Tutorial town	Built
Yale	Boom river port	Design reference complete (this document) — not yet built
Lytton	Canyon crossroads	Not started
Spences Bridge	Ferry and bridge economy	Not started
Ashcroft	Supply and ranching	Not started
Cache Creek	Road junction	Not started
Lillooet	Mile 0 of the Cariboo Road	Not started
Williams Lake	Ranching frontier	Not started
Quesnel	Sternwheeler logistics hub	Not started
Barkerville	Peak gold-rush city	Not started

Source: Gold Rush Trail Visitor Guide, © 2022 Gold Rush Trail / Cariboo Chilcotin Coast Tourism Association.
Compiled and expanded for internal Boomtown project use.